

"I see optimism among people to make India a developed nation by 2047. This energy is my driving force. *Hum GYAN pe dhyaan denge.* GYAN is G for *Garib*, Y for *Yuva*, A for *Annadata*, N for *Narishakti*"

to build on the gains of the past year and take collective steps for the peace and prosperity of our people and our planet.

Q. You had famously said this is not an era of war. Apart from Ukraine, the Gaza war and other mini conflicts rage. India played a deft balancing act throughout these crises. Is there a 'Modi Way' out of this global disorder?
I have always believed that honest dialogue and sincere diplomacy, in an atmosphere free from fear and coercion, should be the preferred path to resolve differences. Be it Ukraine or Gaza, our approach has been guided by this belief. We cannot let terrorists or violence set the agenda. Those who had no role in causing conflicts are often the most affected by them, either directly or indirectly. Giving primacy to diplomacy does not mean that we compromise when it comes to terrorism and territorial sovereignty.

Q. What about dealing with our neighbours, especially Pakistan and China?
The Modi way of dealing with our neighbours is to be constructive and cooperative when required and, equally, to be firm and steadfast when needed. Both on initiatives and challenges, you can see the difference with the past.

Q. Looking ahead, what are the key thrust areas your government will be focusing on to ensure that India becomes Viksit Bharat by 2047?
If you observe closely, there is a historic parallel to the times we are living in. A hundred years ago, there was optimism about gaining freedom. From 1922 to the period up to 1947, everyone wanted to contribute towards the freedom movement. Some contributed by spinning khadi, some by taking part in various movements, people contributed in whatever way they could. The next 25 years are crucial for the nation. I see a similar optimism among the people to make India a developed country by the time we celebrate 100 years of independence. This energy is my driving force. *Hum GYAN pe dhyaan denge, GYAN ko sammaan denge, toh Viksit Bharat banega*. (If we focus on knowledge and respect it, we will become a developed nation) GYAN means G for *Garib*, Y for *Yuva*, A for *Annadata*, N for *Narishakti*. India has a demographic advantage. This advantage must be converted to productivity and economic growth.

Q. How do you propose to press home these advantages that India has?
My foremost priority in making India developed by 2047 will be to ensure good health and fitness for our youth and equip them with appropriate skills. Skilling starts right from our schools, where each classroom has the potential to equip young minds to think innovatively and solve problems. Thus, we are developing an education system through National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 that prepares our children to face the challenges of the 21st century, one that teaches them to convert obstacles into opportunities.

Q. What would your approach be towards industry and investments?
It is our priority to support and nurture small and mid-sized businesses and improve their productivity. Growth in the size of these enterprises is vital for creating high-productivity and high-wage jobs on a large scale. We are working to provide them easy capital, access to technology, more opportunities and more regulatory flexibility. A growing India aiming to attain the status of a 'developed country' by 2047 will require financing of investments through varied and innovative sources. Preparing India's financial sector and capital markets in terms of skills, capacity and regulatory framework to enable it to meet India's investment needs is an important priority for me. In addition to the factors required for creating a facilitative business ecosystem in the country, we will focus on making India's exports competitive. This will incentivise innovation and the production of economically sophisticated products. Governance reform is close to my heart. Performance accountability and capacity building are two pillars of effective governance that we will strengthen.

Q. On a more personal note, you have been in key leadership posts for over 22 years, whether as a chief minister and now as a prime minister. What would you say have been the key lessons that you have learnt, the mantras of your success?
My successes are in the public domain and so are my efforts. So people are free to deduce mantras of success. The one thing that I have adhered to is: Nation First. Everything I have done, as a *karyakarta*, as a CM and as PM, I have always put the nation first. Every decision I have taken has been taken with the national interest in mind. Often people ask me about how I took a difficult decision. For me, it does not seem difficult as I take all my decisions through the prism of Nation First.

Q. What is your wish-list for the coming New Year?
I am not a person who believes in a wish-list, rather I am someone who believes in a work-list for myself. ■